



COODU TRUST

ANNUAL REPORT (2002-2003)

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H-83, R.M. Colony, Dindigul - 624 001.
Ph: 0451-2461362

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OVERVIEW

Agricultural stagnation, rapid population growth and environmental degradation have been common to most southern districts in Tamil Nadu in recent decades. Agriculture has become a risky business in all the rural pockets. Future generations will be worse off as a result of environmental degradation that results from economic decisions made today. Excessive water withdrawals have contributed to several environmental problems besides depletion of ground and surface water. Water resource management is absolutely the need of the hour and every citizen in Tamil Nadu must be aware of the importance of protecting water - the elixir of life. COODU Trust has been concentrating on water resource management for the past five years since Tamil Nadu is now facing acute shortage of water. Responding to the productivity consequences of this degradation is difficult for most farmers in target districts. Yields and total harvests of important food crops are declining in all the districts covered by the COODU Trust.

ANALYSIS MADE DURING THE YEAR

Comprehensive analyses of ground / surface water and soil degradation have been made by our Trust in 9 districts which indicate that the consequences are not large for aggregate agricultural productivity, although they are a concern in every district for susceptible practice. Rural economy is badly affected in the absence of water resources and the economy has offset a part of economic growth as conventionally measured. As a result of the analyses made, projects have been formulated to overcome the difficulties experienced by the rural population. In some pockets deforestation has led to loss of bio-diversity and ecosystems that local people and indigenous communities may value in their own right.

TARGET REGIONS FOR IMPLEMENTING PROJECTS

COODU TRUST's Watershed Management strategies have set priorities in water resources as an essential component synthesized by several government agencies in reports submitted to the Government of Tamil Nadu. COODU TRUST longed to draw on local values, knowledge and experience and accordingly involved local communities in all the project besides government agencies. So far, we have adopted 9 Districts of Tamil Nadu to carry out the important task of watershed Development. Our planned participation in 9 Districts development have eased resolution of the conflicts inherent in environmental decision making.

As a result, agricultural intensification has lessened pressure on forest lands, waste lands and low-input cropping in temperate areas in Tamil Nadu. Our projects are 'on-going' in Karur, Dindigul, Theni, Madurai, Tiruchi, Namakkal, Salem, Tirunelveli, and Sivagangai districts.

TARGET BENEFICIARIES / GROUPS

COODU TRUST's target groups are oppressed and marginal communities in rural pockets, mostly small and marginal farmers and their deprived families. Rural women form the focus groups as 'environmental managers'.

Women in all these districts are brought under our care as a part of our campaign "Feminization of Agriculture".

SIGNIFICANT ACTIVITIES CARRIED OUT DURING THE YEAR 2002 - 2003

WATERSHED DEVELOPMENT PROGRAMMES

The above programme is carried out in 9 districts of Tamil Nadu in coordination with the concerned DRDAs of the state Government. Under DPAP / IWDP / TNCWP / NWDPRA these programmes are implemented in respective



blocks of the districts in which community participation is essential for overall development of water and land resources. Agricultural Engineers and social workers work in the project besides agronomists. Under the direct

supervision of experts the activities are going on to protect the water tables and the recharging capacities of soil.

The following watershed development projects are being implemented at present :-



SIGNIFICANT ACTIVITIES CARRIED OUT DURING THE YEAR OF 2002 - 2003

COODU Trust has dedicated itself in the process of community development, the backbone for the present watershed programme implementation. As believed by Govt of India that the Voluntary agencies can execute community development precisely than any other departments, COODU Trust has engaged in community development activities and awareness creation for watershed projects, which results in active participation of villagers in project implementation.

For community development COODU Trust have carried out the works as per the GOI watershed guidelines viz., Formal and Informal meeting, Awareness campaigns, PRA exercises and also involves in ensuring the works are completed as per the need of the people abiding GOI guidelines. The following programmes were executed during 2002 - 2003.

Sl. No.	District / Block	Project / No. of Watersheds	Project / No. of Watersheds	No. of participants
1.	Dindigul - Natham, Athoor & Kodaikanal	DPAP & 14 watersheds	Informal Meeting Conducted Formal Meeting Conducted Awareness Campaign Conducted Cultural Programmes Conducted PRA Exercises Conducted User Group Formation Self Help Group Formation Watershed Association Formation Watershed Committee Formation	350 Nos. 1750 Nos. 2380 Nos. 7000 Nos. 4200 Nos. 764 Nos. 450 Nos. 14 Nos. 14 Nos.
	Dindigul - Shanarpatty	IWDP 10 Watersheds	Informal Meeting Conducted Formal Meeting Conducted Awareness Campaign Conducted Cultural Programmes Conducted PRA Exercises Conducted User Group Formation Self Help Group Formation Watershed Association Formation Watershed Committee Formation	300 Nos. 1000 Nos. 2000 Nos. 5000 Nos. 3000 Nos. 1000 Nos. 250 Nos. 10 Nos. 10 Nos.

Sl. No.	District / Block	Project / No. of Watersheds	Project / No. of Watersheds	No. of participants
2.	Dindigul - Veda sandur	IWDP 20 Watersheds	Informal Meeting Conducted Formal Meeting Conducted Awareness Campaign Conducted Cultural Programmes Conducted PRA Exercises Conducted User Group Formation Self Help Group Formation Watershed Association Formation Watershed Committee Formation Exposure visit to Horticulture Farm, Periyakulam Exposure visit to Rajasthan and other state	600 Nos. 2000 Nos. 4000 Nos. 10000 Nos. 6000 Nos. 2000 Nos. 1000 Nos. 20 Nos. 20 Nos. 400 Nos. 70 Nos.
	Dindigul - Nilakottai	TNCWP 4 Watersheds	Informal Meeting Conducted Formal Meeting Conducted Awareness Campaign Conducted Cultural Programmes Conducted PRA Exercises Conducted Area Group Formation User Group Formation Self Help Group Formation Village Development Association Formation Exposure Visit to Tirunelveli	120 Nos. 450 Nos. 750 Nos. 1500 Nos. 1000 Nos. 152 Nos. 150 Nos. 150 Nos. 4 Nos. 80 Nos.
	Dindigul Thoppampatty	NWDPR 6	Informal Meeting Conducted Formal Meeting Conducted	300 Nos. 1000 Nos.
	Karur - Kadavur	IWDP 23 Watersheds	Informal Meeting Conducted Formal Meeting Conducted Awareness Campaign Conducted Cultural Programmes Conducted PRA Exercises Conducted User Group Formation Self Help Group Formation Watershed Association Formation Watershed Committee Formation Farmers Exposure visit	920 Nos. 1150 Nos. 3450 Nos. 10350 Nos. 6750 Nos. 2300 Nos. 1220 Nos. 23 Nos. 23 Nos. 60 Nos.

Sl. No.	District / Block	Project / No. of Watersheds	Project / No. of Watersheds	No. of participants
3.	Karur - Thogamalai	IWDP 12 Watersheds	Informal Meeting Conducted	360 Nos.
			Formal Meeting Conducted	1320 Nos.
			Awareness Campaign Conducted	5400 Nos.
			Cultural Programmes Conducted	8400 Nos.
			PRA Exercises Conducted	3000 Nos.
			User Group Formation	700 Nos.
			Self Help Group Formation	300 Nos.
	Madurai - Alanganallur	IWDP 10 Watersheds	Informal Meeting Conducted	300 Nos.
			Formal Meeting Conducted	1000 Nos.
			Awareness Campaign Conducted	2000 Nos.
			Cultural Programmes Conducted	5000 Nos.
			PRA Exercises Conducted	3000 Nos.
			User Group Formation	600 Nos.
			Self Help Group Formation	420 Nos.
			Watershed Association Formation	10 Nos.
			Watershed Committee Formation	10 Nos.
			Farmers Exposure visit to Tirunelveli	80 Nos.
	Madurai - North, South, etc.,	NWDPR 10 Watersheds	Informal Meeting Conducted	310 Nos.
			Formal Meeting Conducted	600 Nos.
			Awareness Campaign Conducted	1020 Nos.
			Cultural Programmes Conducted	2040 Nos.
			PRA Exercises Conducted	2480 Nos.
			User Group Formation	700 Nos.
			Self Help Group Formation	450 Nos.
			Watershed Association Formation	10 Nos.
			Watershed Committee Formation	10 Nos.

Sl. No.	District / Block	Project / No. of Watersheds	Project / No. of Watersheds	No. of participants
4.	Theni - Periakulam	IWDP 10 Watersheds	Informal Meeting Conducted Formal Meeting Conducted Awareness Campaign Conducted Cultural Programmes Conducted PRA Exercises Conducted User Group Formation Self Help Group Formation Watershed Association Formation Watershed Committee Formation	250 Nos. 1000 Nos. 2000 Nos. 5000 Nos. 3000 Nos. 450 Nos. 300 Nos. 10 Nos. 10 Nos.
	Theni - Andipatty	TNCWP 13 Watersheds	Informal Meeting Conducted Formal Meeting Conducted Awareness Campaign Conducted Cultural Programmes Conducted PRA Exercises Conducted Area Group Formation User Group Formation Self Help Group Formation Watershed Association Formation Watershed Committee Formation	360 Nos. 1200 Nos. 2400 Nos. 6200 Nos. 3750 Nos. 1620 Nos. 520 Nos. 325 Nos. 13 Nos. 13 Nos.
5.	Trichy - Thathaiyangar pettai	IWDP 12 Watersheds	Informal Meeting Conducted Formal Meeting Conducted Awareness Campaign Conducted Cultural Programmes Conducted PRA Exercises Conducted User Group Formation Self Help Group Formation Watershed Association Formation Watershed Committee Formation	360 Nos. 1200 Nos. 2400 Nos. 6200 Nos. 3750 Nos. 420 Nos. 600 Nos. 12 Nos. 12 Nos.

Sl. No.	District / Block	Project / No. of Watersheds	Project / No. of Watersheds	No. of participants
6.	Tirunelveli - Nanguneri & Kalakkadu	IWDP 20 Watersheds	Informal Meeting Conducted	600 Nos.
			Formal Meeting Conducted	2000 Nos.
			Awareness Campaign Conducted	4000 Nos.
			Cultural Programmes Conducted	10000 Nos.
			PRA Exercises Conducted	6000 Nos.
			User Group Formation	2200 Nos.
			Self Help Group Formation	2800 Nos.
			Watershed Association Formation	20 Nos.
			Watershed Committee Formation	20 Nos.
	Tirunelveli - Kuruvikulam	DPAP 4 Watersheds	Informal Meeting Conducted	120 Nos.
			Formal Meeting Conducted	450 Nos.
			Awareness Campaign Conducted	800 Nos.
			Cultural Programmes Conducted	2000 Nos.
			PRA Exercises Conducted	1500 Nos.
			User Group Formation	120 Nos.
			Self Help Group Formation	60 Nos.
			Watershed Association Formation	4 Nos.
			Watershed Committee Formation	4 Nos.
	Tirunelveli - Manur	TNCWP 16 Watersheds	Informal Meeting Conducted	480 Nos.
			Formal Meeting Conducted	1800 Nos.
			Awareness Campaign Conducted	3000 Nos.
			Cultural Programmes Conducted	6200 Nos.
			PRA Exercises Conducted	4000 Nos.
			Area Group Formation	3200 Nos.
			User Group Formation	800 Nos.
			Self Help Group Formation	1100 Nos.
			Village Development Association Formation	16 Nos.

Sl. No.	District / Block	Project / No. of Watersheds	Project / No. of Watersheds	No. of participants
7.	Namakkal - Erumaipatty	TNCWP 7 Watersheds	Informal Meeting Conducted Formal Meeting Conducted Awareness Campaign Conducted Cultural Programmes Conducted PRA Exercises Conducted Area Group Formation User Group Formation Self Help Group Formation Village Development Association Formation	225 Nos. 775 Nos. 950 Nos. 2700 Nos. 1900 Nos. 940 Nos. 350 Nos. 200 Nos. 7 Nos.
8.	Salem - Tharamangalam	TNCWP 12 Watersheds	Informal Meeting Conducted Formal Meeting Conducted Awareness Campaign Conducted Cultural Programmes Conducted PRA Exercises Conducted Area Group Formation User Group Formation Self Help Group Formation Village Development Association Formation	380 Nos. 1400 Nos. 2280 Nos. 4560 Nos. 3000 Nos. 1200 Nos. 600 Nos. 480 Nos. 12 Nos.
	Salem - Kolathur	TNCWP 13 Watersheds	Informal Meeting Conducted Formal Meeting Conducted Awareness Campaign Conducted Cultural Programmes Conducted PRA Exercises Conducted Area Group Formation User Group Formation Self Help Group Formation Village Development Association Formation	410 Nos. 1500 Nos. 2475 Nos. 4960 Nos. 3250 Nos. 1950 Nos. 910 Nos. 520 Nos. 13 Nos.

Sl. No.	District / Block	Project / No. of Watersheds	Project / No. of Watersheds	No. of participants
9.	Sivagangai - Sivagangai, Manamadurai	IWDP 10 Watersheds	Informal Meeting Conducted	250 Nos.
			Formal Meeting Conducted	1000 Nos.
			Awareness Campaign Conducted	2000 Nos.
			Cultural Programmes Conducted	5000 Nos.
			PRA Exercises Conducted	3000 Nos.
			User Group Formation	450 Nos.
			Self Help Group Formation	300 Nos.
			Watershed Association Formation	10 Nos.
			Watershed Committee Formation	10 Nos.
	Sivagangai - Kallal, Devakottai, Singampunari	DPAP 6 Watersheds	Informal Meeting Conducted	300 Nos.
			Formal Meeting Conducted	650 Nos.
			Awareness Campaign Conducted	950 Nos.
			Cultural Programmes Conducted	1090 Nos.
			PRA Exercises Conducted	1500 Nos.
			User Group Formation	350 Nos.
			Watershed Association Formation	6 Nos.
			Watershed Committee Formation	6 Nos.

RAINWATER HARVESTING

COODU TRUST has recognised the true value of natural resources and the value of water for existence. Rainwater is precious and the erratic monsoons in Tamil Nadu have failed the hopes of farming community. Hence, we conducted various programmes to increase the knowledge base to meet the growing demand for adequate water sources in all our operational villages during the reporting year.

Demonstrations were held by experts on rain water harvesting and ways to avoid depletion of ground and surface water. Even rural women participated in such programmes. Ponds in our operational areas were renewed for retention of rain water during rainy season. Local panchayats were also involved in the activity alongwith SHG women in villages. Structural arrangements have been constructed near borewells and Open wells.



Recharging abandoned well

CONSERVATION OF MEDICINAL PLANTS

Indigenous medicinal plants are natural resources and are exported to foreign countries from our State since they have wonderful medicinal value without side effects. The medicinal plants sector is gaining popularity. Farmers are reluctant to cultivate the herbs in large scale because of ignorance on marketing the produce. COODU TRUST has conducted several programmes on this important aspect. Training workshops on cultivation of medicinal plants endemic to Tamil Nadu (Western Ghats) were



Gardening with medicinal plants

held in various districts involving small and marginal farmers. Rural women participated in large number in certain districts. Kitchen Herbal Gardens were the main subject for the women. Women groups came forward to promote Homestead Gardens in their villages if assistance and agro techniques were provided. COODU Trust provided the support and the agro techniques to them.

TRAINING FARMERS ON INDIGENOUS FARMING

COODU TRUST has always recognised the need to establish smaller organisational units, such as village committees, farmers associations, are better equipped to manage their own resources and be more effective basis for rural development and rational resource management than institutions imposed from outside. Farmers in Tamil Nadu face only one major constraint today - water scarcity. Besides this major problem, the lands have become fully chemicalised. Increased water pollution from nonpoint agricultural sources and alteration of hydrologic systems in Tamil Nadu have been seriously studied by our expert teams in all the districts. Farmers have totally forgotten ancient farming practices, otherwise termed as Indigenous Farming. The practice insists natural fertilisers, natural pesticides and organic farming besides Bio-fertilisers. In the absence of future expansion of irrigation, high value crops are grown on unlevelled land and permeable soils where traditional surface irrigation is impossible.

COODU TRUST conducted training programmes on the following indigenous farming practices:-

- Organic Farming / Natural Farming

- Biofertilizers out of coir piths and solid wastes.

- Herbal pesticides / Panchakavya to control pests.

- Vermi compost to enrich the soil

- Cultivation of small millets for food security.

- Tree ecology, tree plantation programmes / horticulture

- Agroforestry (after agroecological zoning and community involvement in hilly terrains)

- Sustainable agricultural practices suitable to respective ecosystems in various Districts of Tamil Nadu.

SUSTAINABLE AGRICULTURE - TRAINING

Sustainable development is development that lasts. COODU TRUST strongly believes in the investments in natural resources improvement in soil fertility, reforestation, watershed development and 'returning to Nature' so that we can safely pass on to the next generation the wealth of the country. Thus, we take account of the physical, human and natural capital which would determine their welfare and their bequests to their successors. Sustainable Agriculture, a new concept, has gained popularity in



recent years. COODU TRUST's research team's study revealed the potential magnitudes of the adjustments required in various fields such as soil, forests and ground water. The study revealed that economic activity and the environment has closer links. Keeping this mind, we conducted various training workshops and seminars on Sustainable Agriculture in various districts declared as drought prone, by the Government. Social preferences in every block were considered before preparing the training schedules for programmes. Gandhigram Rural Institute and the Krishi Vigyan Kendra, GRI guided us in the respect. Publications on the subject were published in the interests of the farming community in target blocks. It is estimated by World Bank that doubling food production in India by 2030 could be achieved by maintaining



past rates of crop yields but will require a four fold increase in fertilise application. By 2030 average yeilds in India would have to reach the level of those in China today. COODU TRUST prefers to have natural, biofertilizer application to increase the productivity of the soil degraded in Tamil Nadu. Our programmes on Sustainable Agriculture are aimed at building the positive links.

FEMINIZATION OF AGRICULTURE

At the village level, rural women are the most affected by environment problems-yet women also have the most potential to create change. They are the best 'environmental managers' and custodians of natural resources in any region. COODU TRUST has formed innumerable women groups in its target villages who are directly involved in environmental



protection and biodiversity conservation. Even Tree planting programmes are undertaken by Rural Self Help Groups. The women groups in Madurai, Theni and Dindigul have been trained by our team to promote Homestead Herbal Gardens. Women know the intrinsic values of environment. Therefore, we have been striving hard to involve rural women in all our activities right from water preservation to waste land development. Our concept Feminization of Agriculture has been successful in our target districts. Some villages in Dindigul District are busy with vermi compost preparation by rural women only.

MICROFINANCE AND POVERTY ALLEVIATION

It is a pity to see the inescapable web of money lenders in almost all parts of Tamil Nadu rural pockets, because of poverty. Middle income families and farmers marginalised are the victims. Throughout their lives, they live in debts. Our Trust has taken a serious view of this miserable plight and has provided microfinance to innumerable Self Help Groups to emancipate poor families from the clutches of money - lenders. Rural entrepreneurship has been promoted in a number of villages. Women entrepreneurs are seen in all our target regions. Women groups are regularly trained on leadership, decision making, microfinance and income generation programmes. It is our earnest desire to make women another bread winners. We have many successful stories as outcome of this activity.

CAPACITY BUILDING - RURAL WOMEN GROUPS

Women Development is focused mainly to ensure their right of ownership of natural resources in their native places. Easy access to education, health and credit will empower the rural women and will pave way to have control over economic resources at last. As such, our women groups have been regularly trained on legal awareness, income generation



programmes, biodiversity conservation and rural development. Women groups have emerged as independent bodies in village. Village committees formed by COODU TRUST have women invariably. We can 'end violence' against women if they are armed with capabilities to encounter adverse situations. Girl's education has been made compulsory in all the families of SHGs. Women Groups meet once in a month and discuss various issues and challenges in rural atmosphere. Throughout the year, they undergo regular training on various subjects aimed at economic empowerment and upliftment. Under Entrepreneur Development Programme, Rural women have been trained on masroom cultivation, Vermi Compost, Beautician course and Toy making etc., in Dindigul District.

RURAL SANITATION

Rural health is badly affected in almost all the villages adapted by COODU TRUST. This reason is attributed to inadequate healthcare facilities and ignorance on medicare among rural people. COODU trust has been concentrating on providing regular medical camps and medicare to rural women and children. Herbal remedies are the best suited to rural women who have no access to PHCs and hospitals.

Annual Report

Indigenous medicinal systems like Siddha and Ayurveda are age old and these practices are encouraged in villages. Kitchen Herbal Gardens and cultivation of large scale medicinal plants are mainly encouraged to revive the ethnomedical heritage of our country. Indigenous Knowledge (IK) on herbal cure has been documented for dissemination among innocent / rustic people in villages. Women are the major beneficiaries of this activity. Under Total Sanitation Campaign (TSC) toilet for individuals / Community have been constructed in Madurai District, Karur District and Dindigul District. Awareness on Hygiene and Sanitation has been generated in all target villages in the during years.

PARTICIPATORY RURAL APPRAISALS

Participatory Rural Appraisal(PRA) exercises have been successful to assess the development agenda prepared by the Project Implementing Agencies (PIAs). COODU TRUST involved several experts in conducting PRA Exercises in our operational villages to ensure community



Resource mapping - PRA Tool

participation and involvement of different sectors of rural people like women groups etc. In these exercises, we could ascertain the local needs and identified the urgent steps to be taken for overall rural development. Some villages were badly in need of check dams to retain running water from hillslopes. The needs identification was recorded in all the PRA exercises especially the watershed development projects in target districts in Tamil Nadu. Based on the PRA's strategies for environmental improvement, management of local water resources and community development were formulated. These exercises proved our strengths to reach the community groups in remote areas. The following techniques were adopted in the PRA areas,

1. Social Mapping
2. Resource Mapping
3. Transect walk
4. Timeline
5. Matrix Ranking
6. Venn Diagram
7. Seasonality diagram
8. SWOT Analysis
9. Finding Problem and Solutions

Local participation was promoted in target regions mitigate the worst effects of environmental degradation. One of the major lessons learnt out of the PRA exercises is that much investments in sanitation ought to be increased.

Reports on PRA exercises conducted have been compiled with all details necessary with the help of experts from Gandhigram Rural University and the Kirshi Vigyan Kendra, Gandhigram , Dindigul District and Govt. authorities in respective districts. It has been concluded that support to local communities-in the form of information, motivation, and technical assistance will come from the PIA and the government in rural areas.

IEC MATERIALS AND PUBLICATIONS

To create an enabling environment, voluntary agencies and government agencies need innumerable IEC materials so that the end-users and the beneficiaries comprehend the project implemented. COODU Trust has brought out innumerable publications, handouts, IEC materials on environment, watershed development, resource management, rural sanitation, herbal remedies, agrotechniques on cultivation of crops, medicinal plants and trees. Educational materials for poor children were also printed and distributed to the poor children in remote hamlets. Self Help Groups and Panchayats were involved in disseminating the IEC materials. This method of dissemination allowed us to materialise helpful changes to occur over a period of time. Innovative technologies like renewable energy, rain water harvest and indigenous farming practices were published. Total Sanitation Campaigns (TSCs) were printed in the form of booklets. The following are the **major publications**.



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